

Cardiff Community Meals

User Stories & Solutions

Prepared for Sarah • 4 August 2026

Each story below reflects a real need identified for one of the platform's five user types. Every story is paired with the specific feature — already built in the working prototype, or planned for the production build — that addresses it.

1. Requester / Referrer

The person needing meals, or whoever is submitting the request on their behalf (self, family, neighbour, or professional).

Story: As someone recovering from illness, I want to request meal support for myself, so that I don't have to cook while I'm unwell.

Solution: The Request Help page offers a direct self-referral option — no professional or family involvement required.

Story: As a family member, I want to refer a relative who's just left hospital, so that they get meals without having to navigate the process themselves.

Solution: The request form includes a "Family member" referrer type. Third-party referrals are flagged for admin confirmation with the recipient before publishing, protecting against unwanted or mistaken referrals.

Story: As a referrer, I want to specify dietary needs and allergies, so the meals I arrange are safe to eat.

Solution: A dedicated dietary needs/allergies field on the request form is passed through to whichever business prepares the meal.

Story: As a requester, I want reassurance that my personal details won't be exposed publicly, so that I feel safe asking for help.

Solution: Public request cards show only a first name and general area (e.g. "Margaret, Cathays") — never a surname or exact address. A consent checkbox is required before submission, and full address/contact details are only ever shared with the business fulfilling the booking.

Story: As a requester or referrer, I want to track progress after submitting a request, so I know when a meal is actually coming.

Solution: The Track Help page shows a live status pipeline — Open for donations → Fully booked → Being prepared → Delivered — for every request, with a reference ID given at submission.

Story: As a GP, hospital discharge team, or social worker, I want a quick, trustworthy way to refer patients, so vulnerable people get support immediately after discharge.

Solution: A "Professional referral" option exists on the request form today; the roadmap (Phase 3) plans direct integration with Cardiff Council and NHS discharge pathways so professionals can refer without leaving their own systems.

2. Donor

Community members who fund meals, one-off or ongoing.

Story: As a community member, I want to see real people who need help nearby, so my donation feels tangible rather than abstract.

Solution: The Donate & Book a Meal page lists anonymised, verified open requests with area, situation, dietary needs, and a live funding progress bar.

Story: As a donor, I want to choose exactly how many meals I fund, so I can give within my own budget.

Solution: Preset tiers (1 meal / 5 meals / 10 meals) plus a custom amount option, priced against Cardiff Council's own Meals on Wheels benchmark (~£7/meal).

Story: As a donor, I want to pick which local business cooks the meal, so I can support a business I already know and like.

Solution: A business selector on the donation form lets donors choose a specific partner, or opt to "let the platform match a nearby business."

Story: As a donor, I want to send an encouraging message with my donation, so the recipient feels cared for, not just fed.

Solution: An optional message field is delivered anonymously alongside the meal.

Story: As a donor, I want proof that my meal actually reached someone, so I trust my money was well spent.

Solution: Every donation is tracked from Booked → Prepared → Delivered on the Track Help page; the production build adds automated email confirmations at each stage.

Story: As a donor, I want to see the platform's overall impact before I commit, so I feel confident it's a legitimate, effective cause.

Solution: The public Impact dashboard shows total meals delivered, funds raised, people helped, and a business leaderboard — updated in real time.

3. Business Partner

Cardiff cafés, restaurants, and caterers who cook and deliver the meals.

Story: As a local café owner, I want to be publicly showcased for helping the community, so I get recognition and new customers.

Solution: The Business Partners page gives every approved partner a public profile: cuisine, hygiene rating, delivery type, and a running meals-delivered count.

Story: As a business, I want a simple, low-effort way to apply and get listed, so I don't need technical skill to take part.

Solution: A short Partner Sign-Up form; in production this triggers an admin review, including verification of the business's current Food Standards Agency hygiene rating, before the profile goes live.

Story: As a business, I want clear delivery details and dietary requirements before I start cooking, so I prepare the right meal safely.

Solution: Booking details — dietary needs, delivery notes, timing — are captured at the point of donation; the production roadmap adds a dedicated business portal with real-time booking notifications.

Story: As a business, I want recognition that grows with my contribution, so I'm motivated to keep taking part.

Solution: Bronze / Silver / Gold "Community Kitchen" badges are awarded automatically based on cumulative meals delivered, shown on the public showcase.

Story: As a business, I want an easy way to update a meal's status as I prepare and deliver it, so donors and admins can see progress without chasing me.

Solution: The Track Help page includes one-tap status controls (Mark prepared / Mark delivered) in the prototype; production replaces this with a proper business-facing portal.

4. Admin / Moderator

The trustee or staff member responsible for safeguarding and platform oversight — the most safety-critical role on the site.

Story: As an admin, I want to review every request before it goes public, so vulnerable people are never listed without proper consent.

Solution: No request reaches the Donate & Book page without admin approval in the production design (the prototype auto-approves, purely to demonstrate the end-to-end flow).

Story: As an admin, I want to verify third-party referrals directly with the recipient, so requests can't be submitted maliciously or by mistake.

Solution: The referral verification step (Section 6 of the platform plan) requires a confirmation call for family/neighbour referrals, or a recognised source (GP, hospital, Age Connects Cardiff & Vale) for professional referrals.

Story: As an admin, I want a single place to see all requests, donations, and businesses, so I can manage the platform and catch problems early.

Solution: The Track Help page provides this view today at prototype scale; the production build adds a dedicated admin console with filtering, exports, and reporting.

Story: As an admin, I want a clear way to escalate a welfare concern spotted during a delivery, so the platform protects people beyond just feeding them.

Solution: A documented escalation path to Cardiff Council Adult Services is described on the How It Works / Safeguarding page and is a required part of admin onboarding.

5. Visitor (general public)

Anyone landing on the site who hasn't yet decided to donate, request, or partner.

Story: As a first-time visitor, I want to understand how the platform works before committing to anything, so I trust it enough to act.

Solution: The How It Works page lays out the three-step process, the safeguarding approach, and answers common questions before asking for any commitment.

Story: As a visitor, I want reassurance this isn't a scam, so I feel safe entering payment or personal details.

Solution: A transparent, real-time Impact dashboard, a public Business Partners showcase, an explicit safeguarding statement, and a direct comparison to Cardiff Council's own Meals on Wheels service all build credibility before any commitment is asked.